

Q I'm planning to breast-feed my baby. Is there anything I can do now to prepare?

One of the best things you can do to prepare for breast-feeding is to go to a breast-feeding class during pregnancy. These are usually short sessions of a couple of hours long, and may be available free in some hospitals, or you can pay for a private one. It's best to go to a class in your last trimester so that all the information is fresh in your mind when your baby arrives. You will either be shown a DVD of breast-feeding, or an experienced mom may come in to demonstrate how it's done. Experts will talk about how to latch your baby on, which positions you can try, and how to get a good milk supply established. The class leader may also discuss potential pitfalls and issues such as how to avoid nipple confusion by not introducing a bottle or pacifier too early, and how to prevent and treat sore nipples. Look for classes run by an accredited lactation counselor or consultant. You may also want to read up on the subject before you give birth so you feel fully prepared. See pages 266–77 for more information on breast-feeding.

Q I've heard of breast-feeding pillows. Is it worth buying one?

Breast-feeding can be a wonderful experience for mother and baby and it is vital that you are comfortable so that you can enjoy your time together. However it is not always easy. When nursing, it is important that you bring your baby up to nipple height rather than lean toward him. In the early weeks when your baby is very small, a good, supportive pillow will allow you to do this without having to take his weight in your arms. There are specially designed breast-feeding pillows and these can be more supportive than a normal pillow.

Similarly, most normal chairs are too high for breast-feeding so many recommend a nursing chair. These should be low and supportive in the right places for you to maintain good feeding positions. You may need to place pillows behind your back for extra support. Your lap should be flat or slightly raised so that your baby tips toward and not away from you. A nursing chair and pillow may reduce the chances of breast-feeding problems.

Q Is there anything I need to buy for breast-feeding?

One of the many benefits of breast-feeding is that it is very economical, but there are a few items you can buy that will support your breast-feeding experience and add to your comfort.

A nursing bra is essential, so it's worth buying two or three comfortable nursing bras. Make sure that the bras you buy have a clasp that you can release with one hand (see p.179), since your arms will be full with a newborn once you start to breast-feed. The bra cups should also open completely so that nothing presses on your breast tissue and leads to blocked ducts or mastitis. Even if you want to decide about whether or not to breast-feed once your baby arrives, you should buy at

least one bra before the birth, since it's not so easy to go shopping once your newborn has arrived. Breast pads, nipple cream, and burp cloths are all additional, but affordable, items.

Breast pumps

You may want to wait to see if you need a breast pump once you're in a routine with breast-feeding, but a manual or electric pump can prove invaluable if you have to bottle-feed your baby at some point.

Buy at least one nursing bra before the birth, since it will be more difficult to go shopping after.

WHAT YOU NEED TO BUY

With the exception of a breast pump, buy everything before the birth and pack them in your bag for the birth so you can start using them right away.



» **A professionally fitted, supportive nursing bra** will be your main purchase. You can get fitted for a bra from about 36 weeks of pregnancy, when a bra fitter will be able to predict what size you will need after the birth (see p.178). You may also want to buy a soft nighttime bra to hold your breast pads in place too.



» **Burp cloths** are useful for draping over your shoulder after nursing to mop up any milk your baby spits up. They can also provide some cover if you want when you're breast-feeding in public, or you can use a shawl or scarf.



» **Disposable or washable breast pads** help to collect milk that leaks when you're not feeding. Slim and discreet pads are available that are extremely absorbent; those without a plastic lining are less likely to irritate your skin and nipples.



» **Breast pumps** enable you to express your milk (see p.272). Manual pumps have a suction cup or shield attached to a bottle, and a pump handle that you operate manually, while electric pumps operate essentially in the same way, but there is an electric motor that operates the pump action to make it a much faster process.



» **Nipple cream** helps to protect and treat sore nipples. Look for pure, hypoallergenic, lanolin-based creams that are paraben free.



» **Front-opening nightie or pajamas** to enable you to nurse easily at night. There are breast-feeding tops that are designed to make breast-feeding easier too.